MERROWFIELD DIGITAL

Playbook: Misdirected disclosure

Document Playbook 04 | Rev 3 | Effective 9 February 2026 | Owner: Security Operations | Review cycle: 12 months

1. What this playbook covers

This playbook covers personal data sent or shown to the wrong person by mistake - a misaddressed email, the wrong attachment, a mail-merge error, a document shared with the wrong recipient. There is no attacker. It is used by the Security Analyst who investigates, from the first alert until the incident is closed.

2. How it is usually recognised

- the sender realising the mistake and reporting it
- a customer reporting that they received someone else's information
- a data loss prevention alert on an external share

3. The first hour

1. Recall the message where the mail system allows it.
2. Contact the recipient, ask them to delete the data, and ask them to confirm in writing.
3. Stop the process that caused the error - the template, the merge or the distribution list - until it is fixed.
4. Establish exactly what the file or message contained.

4. Evidence to preserve

- the message and attachment as sent
- the recipient's confirmation of deletion
- the sender's account of how it happened

5. Establishing the facts a report needs

Whatever is decided, the decision needs these facts, established as early as they can be:

- whose data was disclosed, and how many people in the EU and in India
- which categories: contact details only, or anything more
- whether the recipient opened it
- whether it was protected - a password-protected attachment whose password was not sent is unintelligible to the recipient

6. Reporting

Which reporting procedures apply is settled from the incident's facts by the rules in Plan 01, section 8, and each procedure's deadlines are read from that procedure. This playbook sets no deadline of its own, and the decision belongs to the Data Protection Officer.

A misdirected email involving EU customers' data is assessed under Procedure 01 like any other breach; the harm band decides whether it is reported and whether customers are told.

7. What affected customers should do

When customers are told, the notice gives them these steps, in this order:

- Be alert to unexpected contact from people who know your name, address or order details.
- Merrowfield will never ask you for payment details by email.
- If you received someone else's information from us, please delete it and let us know.

8. Closing the incident

Fix the template or process, clear the sender's address autocomplete, and add a second check where the error could recur.